

THE ILLITERATE WRITER'S

FILM FORUM

THE ELEMENTS OF FILM · PART THREE · PEOPLE

CHAPTER 8 · PERFORMANCE

Is great acting becoming someone else, or simply being there?

HOLLYWOOD BLVD.

Joker · 2019 · 122 min · dir. Todd Phillips · written by Todd Phillips & Scott Silver · Warner Bros.

This is the print edition, with everything the online guide has. Some information will include spoilers, advised to stop at the end of "Before you press play" and resume after the credits.

THE TWO ROADS

STRAIGHT ON, OR A LEFT AT THE VISTA

Hollywood Boulevard runs east until it hits Sunset, and there is a theatre standing on the corner where they meet. Every chapter the room decides at that corner.

*Two films about young men pulled into violence, and two opposite answers to the oldest argument in acting. In *Joker*, Joaquin Phoenix disappears completely: fifty-two pounds lost, a laugh built to hurt, and the Oscar for the most total transformation of his generation.*

City of God was cast almost entirely with young people from Rio de Janeiro's favelas, most of whom had never acted, trained in a workshop and then asked to improvise rather than recite. One performance is built over months. The other is closer to life.

HOLLYWOOD BLVD.

JOKER

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Gotham, 1981. A failed comedian with a condition that makes him laugh uncontrollably is ignored and beaten down by the city, until he stops trying to be ignored.

Why it is on the ballot. It is the purest example of the modern transformation performance: body, voice, laugh and walk all rebuilt from the ground up. Whether you think it is a masterpiece or too much, you will not see Joaquin Phoenix in it.

BEFORE YOU PRESS PLAY

Optional trivia.

HE LOST 52 POUNDS

Phoenix dropped 52 lb (23 kg), eating roughly one sparse meal a day, and describes the weight loss as a way into the character rather than a stunt: "Losing weight affects how you feel. I'll feel hungry. It'll create that constant lack of satisfaction that's so integral to the Joker's personality."

THE LAUGH IS BUILT FROM REAL FOOTAGE

He studied videos of people with pathological laughing and crying, the condition the press identified as pseudobulbar affect. The film never names it: Arthur simply carries a card explaining "a condition that causes sudden, frequent, uncontrollable laughter." Phoenix plays the laugh as pain rather than symptom.

A COMIC-BOOK FILM WON THE TOP PRIZE AT VENICE

It took the Golden Lion in 2019, then two Oscars from eleven nominations — Phoenix for Best Actor and Hildur Guðnadóttir for Best Original Score — and became the first R-rated film to pass a billion dollars worldwide.

WHILE YOU WATCH

Open each one only when you reach it.

THE OPENING

A smile made by hand

Arthur sits at a mirror and pulls his mouth into a smile with his fingers.

Why it matters: The film opens on a man performing. An actor playing a man who cannot stop acting is a hall of mirrors worth keeping in mind.

EVERY LAUGHING FIT

Watch the eyes

When the laugh takes over, watch his eyes and hands rather than his mouth.

Why it matters: The face and the body are telling two different stories at once. That split is the whole performance.

THE BATHROOM

He starts to dance

After the worst night of his life, Arthur locks himself in a public bathroom and begins to move.

Why it matters: The dance replaced a scripted scene. Guðnadóttir had written the cello theme from the screenplay before shooting; Phillips played it on set and Phoenix improvised to it. She later said: "Phoenix just told me a couple of weeks ago that this was the moment where he was really able to find the character."

THE STAIRS

Up, then down

Early on Arthur drags himself up a long outdoor staircase. Later he comes down it.

Why it matters: Same location, same actor, two completely different bodies. You can read the arc in the walk.

AFTER THE CREDITS

Everything here gives the film away. Keep it for afterwards.

OPEN

The music directed the performance

Guðnadóttir's score existed before a frame was shot and was played to the actors on set, which is the reverse of the usual order. She described watching the rushes: "You could tell that the dance was choreographed to the music... he was basically experiencing the same movements that I had experienced when I was writing the music."

OPEN

The talk-show host is a mirror

Robert De Niro plays Murray Franklin, the host. In Scorsese's *The King of Comedy* (1982), De Niro played Rupert Pupkin, the unstable fan stalking the host. The film hands him the other chair.

OPEN

The staircase became a landmark

The steps on West 167th Street in Highbridge, the Bronx, turned into a tourist site almost overnight, with visitors recreating the dance, to the irritation of people who live there.

01 Could you see Phoenix acting, or only Arthur? Which of those is the better performance?

02 Does a transformation this total make you trust the character more, or keep you at a distance?

03 Can you separate the performance from what the film is saying? Should you?

Where to watch

Find it here → [Joker on JustWatch](#), which shows every service carrying it right now, including free ones.

And two nobody uses: **Kanopy** and **Hoopla** are free with a library card. If you find it cheaper or free somewhere else, post the link in [my Substack](#).

Sources: Time Out · IndieWire · Variety

THE LESSON

FEEL IT FOR REAL

A RUSSIAN DIRECTOR DESCRIBED A SYSTEM

Konstantin Stanislavski, co-founder of the Moscow Art Theatre, spent decades writing down how his actors worked: imagining the character's circumstances, finding an objective in every scene, sometimes drawing on their own memories. *An Actor Prepares* reached English readers in 1936 — as a single volume he had never intended, since he meant it and *Building a Character* to be one book. He kept revising the system for the rest of his life.

AN AMERICAN TEACHER MADE IT THE METHOD

In New York, Lee Strasberg took one piece of that system, affective memory, and made it the centre of a technique. As artistic director of the Actors Studio from 1951 he shaped a generation of Studio actors, among them James Dean, Paul Newman and Al Pacino. In his words: "The two areas of discovery that were of primary importance in my work at the Actors Studio and in my private classes were improvisation and affective memory."

THE ARGUMENT STARTED IMMEDIATELY

Stella Adler spent five weeks studying with Stanislavski in Paris in 1934 and came back reporting that he had moved on: actors should build emotion from the given circumstances of the scene and from imagination, not by digging up their own grief. She and Strasberg taught opposing schools for the rest of their careers. The rule that grew out of Strasberg's version — real acting means real feeling, and the proof is transformation — is still roughly how the Oscars vote.

THREE WAYS TO GIVE A PERFORMANCE

ONE

TRANSFORM

The actor rebuilds body, voice and mind to become someone else.

Raging Bull · There Will Be Blood · Joker

TWO

BE PRESENT

Non-professionals cast for who they are and allowed to behave rather than perform.

Bicycle Thieves · The Florida Project · City of God

THREE

BE A STAR

The actor brings the same persona to every role and the film uses it.

Cary Grant · Tom Cruise · Keanu Reeves

None of the three is cheating. The question is which one the film needed.

BEND THE LINE

Lay the ways of putting a person on screen along a line, from the most made to the least: an actor who rebuilds himself entirely, an actor stretching outside his usual register, an actor who brings the same self to every part, and someone who was never trained at all. Most films live in the middle, and none of these is the right answer. Then bend the line.

BECOMING

BEING



Four ways to put a person on screen, from the most made to the least. Bend the line and the two ends meet: all four are after the same thing, getting rid of whatever feels false.

THE METHOD

Rebuilds body, voice and mind until there is nobody left in there to find.

STRETCHING

A trained actor reaching outside their usual register, still recognisably themselves.

THEMSELVES

The same person in every part, and the film is built to use exactly that.

THE NON-ACTOR

Never trained, cast because they already are what the part needs.

Not all acting requires an actor to disappear, and most of it does not. But when a film wants you to believe a character completely, what it needs is authenticity. Sometimes a director finds it by casting someone who already embodies the role's reality. More often it comes from an actor finding the exact point where their own emotional truth meets the character's fictional one. The goal is not to destroy the self, and not to copy reality. It is to eliminate anything that feels fake.

ONE PIECE OF VOCABULARY

Neorealism: the Italian postwar movement that shot in real streets with non-professional actors. *Bicycle Thieves* (1948) cast Lamberto Maggiorani, a factory worker, as its lead — and then he was laid off from the factory, never built a career, and ended up in bit parts. *City of God* is one of that movement's great descendants, and it raises the same question about what happens to people after the film.

WHY THESE FILMS

Chapter 7 was the character on the page. This chapter is the person who has to become it on screen, and the old argument about how. Joker is the Method at its most extreme. City of God asks whether you need acting at all.

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Questions, arguments, films you want on the ballot: heyilliteratewriter@gmail.com

Facts in this guide are drawn from the BFI, Sight and Sound, Time Out, IndieWire, Variety, Roger Ebert and the Academy's records. Where sources disagree, the disagreement is printed rather than resolved.

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